IDEAL CLARITY SOLUTIONS

A TACTICAL GUIDE

Running Your Business *While Employed*

The real-time playbook for corporate professionals building a business on the side — from someone running the play this week, not ten years ago.

Inside: My actual daily schedule, client acquisition messages, stealth-mode tactics, and the systems that let me build without my employer ever knowing.

THE REAL PLAYBOOK

Chi-Chi Jones

FOUNDER · IDEAL CLARITY SOLUTIONS

$27

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The *Myth* of "Quit and Hope"

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Most business advice tells you to quit your job, burn the boats, and go all-in on your dream. It's romantic. It sounds brave. It's also terrible advice for most people.

Here's what they don't tell you: **You can build a real business while staying employed.** I know — because I'm doing it right now.

I'm building Ideal Clarity Solutions while working full-time in corporate. Not as a hobby. Not as "someday." As an active business — with real strategy, real outreach, and real conversations happening as you read this.

> *This isn't a retrospective from someone who* **"made it"** *ten years ago. This is the playbook I'm* **executing this week.**

Most business books are written from the finish line — lessons from the victory lap. This one is different. I'm writing it from the middle of the race. The schedules, the messages, the tools, the mental strategies — everything in these pages is what I'm actually using, right now, while building on the side.

Build *Alongside* Me

WHAT YOU'RE SIGNING UP FOR

If you're a corporate professional who wants to build something of your own but isn't ready — or willing — to take the "quit and pray" leap, this is for you.

You don't need permission. You don't need to risk everything. You don't need the perfect moment. You need a playbook designed for your actual life — the one where you still have a boss, still have a mortgage, and still have to show up at 8 AM tomorrow.

That's what this is.

Read along with me. Build along with me. When one of us has a breakthrough, we both benefit.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- ✓ How to structure your day when you already work 9-to-5
- ✓ How to get clients through conversations — not complicated funnels
- ✓ How to build visibility without your employer ever knowing
- ✓ How to handle the guilt, exhaustion, and quiet fears
- ✓ When to actually quit (and when staying employed is the smarter move)

01

CHAPTER ONE

The Strategic *Framework*

Why building a business while employed isn't just safer — it's often faster, smarter, and more profitable than the "quit and hope" route everyone celebrates.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → The 4 reasons employment is your advantage
- → Why constraints accelerate growth
- → My real revenue timeline (with numbers)
- → How to test before you leap

Why Building While Employed is *Actually Easier*

COUNTERINTUITIVE TRUTH

Everyone tells you entrepreneurship requires "going all-in." That you can't split your focus. That employment is the enemy of building something real.

After doing it both ways, I'm here to tell you: that's wrong. Building while employed isn't a compromise. For most people, **it's the faster, smarter path.** Here's why:

1 SECURITY REMOVES DESPERATION

A steady paycheck means you don't have to close every lead. You can say no to bad-fit clients and charge what you're worth instead of discounting out of fear.

2 BUILT-IN PROOF OF CONCEPT

You're not "that person who quit to chase a dream." You're a corporate professional with a track record launching something new. That's credible. That's trust.

3 THE CONSTRAINT FORCES FOCUS

Limited hours mean you can't waste time on logos, perfect Instagram, or funnels. You're forced to focus on what matters: making offers and getting clients.

4 YOU CAN TEST BEFORE YOU LEAP

Build to $5K/month while employed. Prove the model works. Then — and only then — decide if you want to go full-time. Much less risky than quitting and praying.

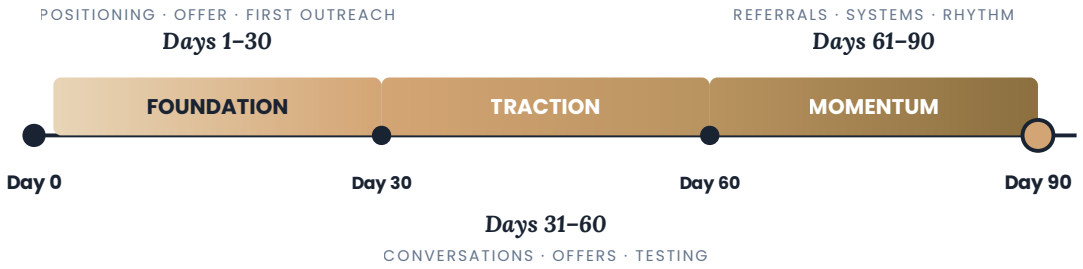
The *90-Day* Rhythm

WHAT BUILDING WHILE EMPLOYED LOOKS LIKE

Most business gurus skip the boring part — the first three months where you're still finding your voice, refining your offer, and running experiments. So here's the realistic arc, based on the rhythm I follow and teach:

The Three Phases of the First 90 Days

FOUNDATION · TRACTION · MOMENTUM



> *Building with a paycheck isn't weakness.* ***It's runway.*** *And runway is what separates sustainable businesses from desperate ones.*

02

CHAPTER TWO

The Daily *Structure*

The #1 question I get is "How do you find the time?" The honest answer: I don't find time. I design my week around predictable, protected windows — and inside this chapter, I'll show you exactly what they look like and how to build yours.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- My hour-by-hour daily schedule
- How to protect your build windows
- The 80/20 of what actually matters
- The "build windows" framework

My Actual *Daily Schedule*

WEEKDAY · WEEKEND · EVERYTHING IN BETWEEN

My build hours happen in two predictable zones: **5:30–8:00 PM** for client calls, and **8:00–10:00 PM** for deep build work. Friday night I extend. Weekend afternoons I expand. Your numbers will shift based on your life — kids, partners, responsibilities — but the principle is the same: *protect the windows, show up inside them.*

WEEKDAY SCHEDULE (MON–THU)

6:00 AM	Wake up, coffee, morning reset	*Slow start, intentional*
8:00 AM–5:00 PM	**CORPORATE JOB**	*Fully present, no side work*
5:00–5:30 PM	Commute, reset, transition	*Switch mental modes*
5:30–8:00 PM	**CLIENT CALLS — Window #1**	*Or flex time if no calls scheduled*
8:00–10:00 PM	**BUILD — Window #2**	*Content · Strategy · Deep work*
10:00 PM	Wind down, rest	*Recovery is part of the plan*

Friday Night, *Weekend Build*

STRETCH WHEN YOU CAN, REST WHEN YOU NEED

Building while employed isn't about balance in any given day. It's about balance across the week. Some days I give more, some days I give less. The only rule: the total shows up consistently.

FRIDAY EXTENDED WINDOW

5:30–8:00 PM	Client calls or flex time	*Same as weekdays*
8:00 PM–12:00 AM	**BUILD — Extended Window**	*4 hours of focused work*

WEEKEND BUILD WINDOWS

Saturday 1:00–6:00 PM	**BUILD + Client Calls**	*5 hours · Morning & evening off*
Sunday 1:00–5:00 PM	**BUILD + Client Calls**	*4 hours · Evening prep for Monday*

4.5
HOURS / WEEKDAY

33.5
HOURS / WEEK

$37
MONTHLY TECH STACK

MAKE IT YOURS

Your schedule will look nothing like mine — and that's fine. If you have kids, a partner, caregiving duties, or other responsibilities, build your windows around them. **The principle isn't the hours. It's the consistency.** Pick your windows, protect them like meetings with your most important client (because they are), and show up.

The 80/20 of Building While Employed

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

Whether you have 10 hours a week or 30+, you cannot afford to do everything. Most entrepreneurs fail here. They spread their precious time across twenty things that don't move the needle.

Here's what actually generates revenue vs. what feels productive but isn't:

✓ THE 20% THAT MATTERS

Revenue-Driving Activities

- Making offers to real people
- Having sales conversations
- Delivering exceptional work for clients
- Creating content that attracts ideal clients
- Following up with warm leads

✕ THE 80% THAT WASTES

Time-Stealing Distractions

- Perfect logo design
- Complicated marketing funnels
- Building elaborate websites
- Optimizing Instagram aesthetics
- Taking more courses and certifications

> *My rule: if it doesn't* **directly lead to a conversation** *with a potential client or serve an existing client, it's a low-priority task.* **Ask this before every action.**

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CHAPTER THREE

Getting Clients *Without* Marketing

You don't have time for funnels, ads, or TikTok dances. You need conversations — real conversations with real people that lead to real offers. Here's the exact method I'm using to do that, without a marketing budget or a complicated tech stack.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The Warm Outreach Method
- The Strategic Content rule
- Word-for-word messages I sent
- My actual conversion numbers

Strategy #1: The *Warm Outreach* Method

HOW IT WORKS

Forget cold DMs. Forget lead magnets funneling into five-email sequences. When you're short on time, your **existing network** is your unfair advantage.

1. **Make a list of 20 people**

   Former colleagues, classmates, LinkedIn contacts you've actually had conversations with. Not strangers. People who would remember your name and respond.

2. **Send personalized reconnection messages**

   Not pitches. Not sales letters. Actual "hey, how are you" messages that reference something specific about them.

3. **Have real conversations**

   Ask about their life, their work, what they've been up to. Let them share. Genuine curiosity is magnetic — and increasingly rare.

4. **Make offers naturally**

   When the conversation turns to what you're building, invite them in. Not "buy my program" — "would this be useful for you?"

THE NUMBERS THAT MAKE THIS WORK

20	10+	0
WARM MESSAGES	EXPECTED REPLIES	AD SPEND NEEDED

The *Exact Message* I Sent

WORD FOR WORD

Here's the exact template I use — the kind of message that starts real conversations instead of ending up in the LinkedIn "dismissed" pile:

ACTUAL MESSAGE

Hey Sarah!

It's been a minute — how have you been? I've been thinking about our days in Field Operations and wanted to reach out.

I'm actually building something new while still working full-time, and you came to mind because I remember you talking about wanting to start that leadership coaching business.

Did you ever move forward with that? Or did life take you in a different direction?

Would love to catch up if you're open to it!

— Chi-Chi

WHY THIS WORKS

Notice what's **not** in this message: no pitch, no "check out my program," no "I'd love to work with you." Just genuine reconnection with a specific reference. The conversation naturally led to discussing what I'm building — on her terms, not mine.

Strategy #2: *Scheduled Consistency*

Content is what keeps your audience warm between outreach cycles. My approach: **schedule a week's worth at a time**, then adjust as life allows. Some weeks that's daily posts. Other weeks it's 1–3. Either way, I'm never scrambling to write in the moment.

THE BATCHING APPROACH

Schedule It Once, Post It All Week

I batch-write posts in one sitting and schedule them out. This removes the "I need to post today" pressure and keeps content flowing even on weeks when life gets loud. Tools like LinkedIn's native scheduler, Buffer, or Metricool make this free or near-free.

THE CONTENT MIX THAT CONVERTS

There's no single "right" kind of post. In stealth mode especially, variety is your friend — a mix of angles keeps you from looking like a one-note personal brand while your colleagues are watching. What matters is that each post, in its own way, *signals something to your ideal client.*

- **Pattern recognition posts** — Name what your audience is living
- **Micro-story posts** — A small moment with a big insight
- **Reframes** — Challenge a common belief your ideal client holds
- **Signal posts** — Show what you know, not that you're selling
- **Even the occasional motivational or reflective post** — in stealth mode, it adds to the "this is just a thoughtful professional" effect

> *Stealth mode isn't about what you post — **it's about how you frame it.** A motivational post and a business post can both serve you, if the framing is right.*

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CHAPTER FOUR

Stealth *Mode*

Real talk: you don't want your boss seeing your side hustle plastered across social media. These are the exact strategies I use to build visibility with my target market while staying completely off my employer's radar.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → LinkedIn timing & visibility tricks
- → Separating business from personal
- → Language choices that keep you safe
- → The "Followers not Friends" approach

LinkedIn *Stealth Mode*

FOUR STRATEGIES THAT WORK

1 STRATEGY · SELECTIVE VISIBILITY

Post Outside Work Hours

Post sparingly between 9 AM–5 PM. Most of my posts go live between **5:30–7:30 AM** or **5:30–7:30 PM**. This targets people scrolling *outside* work, not colleagues during their lunch break.

2 STRATEGY · LANGUAGE CHOICES

Reframe, Don't Reveal

Don't say: "Quit my corporate job to pursue my dreams."
Do say: "Exploring how I can serve people beyond my day job." Phrases like "*on the side*" and "*a passion project*" read as curious and professional — not plotting an exit.

3 STRATEGY · PROFILE OPTIMIZATION

Don't Declare "Founder" Yet

My headline isn't "CEO & Founder." It's "[Corporate Role] · Helping professionals break through execution blocks." Lead with your corporate credibility. Mention the side project casually. Save the "Founder" title for when you're ready to leave.

4 STRATEGY · CONNECTION SETTINGS

Followers > Direct Connections

Don't actively connect with direct reports or your immediate team. If they find and request, use the **"Followers"** feature — they see your updates but less prominently. And they can't see who else follows you.

Beyond LinkedIn: *Instagram, Facebook & TikTok*

WHERE YOUR REAL AUDIENCE LIVES

LinkedIn is where your colleagues are. **Instagram, Facebook, and TikTok are where your clients are.** That distinction matters — especially when you're building in stealth.

Your corporate network probably isn't scrolling TikTok looking for your content. They're not combing your Instagram grid. This is your zone of creative freedom — where you can be louder, bolder, more *you* — without setting off alarms at work.

THE THREE-PLATFORM PLAYBOOK

- **Instagram Reels** — Short, visual storytelling. Lean into micro-stories and reframes. Reach strangers without needing a big following.
- **Facebook** — Longer reflective posts and lives. Great for the 45+ demographic and warm networks. Post once, let it breathe for days.
- **TikTok** — The algorithm rewards bold, direct, polarizing content. If you can be a little uncomfortable on camera, you win.

> **THE STEALTH BENEFIT**
>
> Here's the quiet magic: **your corporate colleagues almost never see this content.** They're not your Instagram followers. They're not on your TikTok. You can be a completely different, braver version of yourself on these platforms — and still walk into your 8 AM Monday meeting as the same composed professional they've always known.

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CHAPTER FIVE

The *Mental* Game

The hardest part of building while employed isn't the logistics or the schedule. It's the guilt, the exhaustion, and the quiet voice asking "am I being disloyal?" Here's how to navigate all three without burning out or burning bridges.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → Working through employer guilt
- → The disloyalty question
- → Preventing burnout — for real
- → Staying sane in a double life

The *Guilt*

"AM I GIVING LESS THAN 100%?"

You'll feel it. Guaranteed. That little voice asking: "*I'm giving less than 100% to my employer. Am I being dishonest?*"

Here's the reality check that shut that voice up for me:

- ✓ You're still delivering on every corporate responsibility
- ✓ Your employer gets 40 hours/week of your best, focused work
- ✓ What you do with your other 128 hours is yours
- ✓ They're not paying you for weekends, evenings, or 5:30 AM

> *I am 100% present during work hours. I don't take client calls during my workday. I don't check my business email.* **Corporate gets my full attention 8 AM–5 PM.**

The Exhaustion

Working "two jobs" sounds exhausting because it is. You will have weeks where you're running on fumes, wondering if this is sustainable. The answer?

THE SPRINT MINDSET

This is a sprint with a finish line in view

This isn't forever. The intensity of building while employed is a **season**, not a permanent state. As your systems develop and your income stabilizes, you'll reach a decision point: stay employed at a reduced pace, or go full-time. Either way, the grind has an ending. *Knowing that makes every hard week bearable.*

The *Disloyalty* Question

THE QUIETEST, MOST PAINFUL ONE

Somewhere along the way, you'll ask yourself: *"My employer has been good to me. Am I betraying them by planning something on the side?"*

It's a fair question — and it deserves a fair answer. Here's the reframe that settled it for me:

- Your employer would lay you off tomorrow if it served their business needs — so the loyalty runs one direction
- You don't owe anyone your entire professional future
- Building something of your own actually makes you *better* at your day job — more strategic, more accountable, more invested in your craft
- Loyalty is doing excellent work while you're there. Not staying forever out of guilt.

> *You can honor your current role fully **and** still build your future. Those things aren't in conflict — they're just on different schedules.*

THE INTEGRITY TEST

Are You Being Honest With Yourself?

If you're giving your employer your best 40 hours, not using company resources, and keeping your side work out of work hours — you're being honest. Guilt is a feeling. **Integrity is a practice.** As long as your practice is clean, the feeling will pass.

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CHAPTER SIX

The *Decision* Framework

The #1 question I get: "When should I quit?" The answer isn't emotional. It's mathematical. Here's the exact framework I use — and why I'm choosing to build with intention, not urgency.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The 5 "Don't Quit Yet" criteria
- Staying employed: the case
- Why I'm building with intention
- The financial stress test

When To *Quit*

(AND WHEN NOT TO)

The internet tells you to quit as soon as you "believe in yourself." That's terrible advice. Real entrepreneurs quit based on numbers, not vibes.

DON'T QUIT UNTIL ALL OF THESE ARE TRUE

- ✓ Your business revenue = **50-75%** of your corporate salary for 3+ consecutive months
- ✓ You have **6 months of expenses** saved (separate from business capital)
- ✓ You've stress-tested the model — proven you can get clients *consistently*
- ✓ You have a plan for health insurance, benefits, retirement
- ✓ You're mentally ready for the income variability

Consider Staying Employed If...

- Your corporate job isn't soul-crushing
- You can maintain $10K-20K/month business while employed
- You value the stability, benefits, and retirement contributions
- Your employer is flexible about hours
- **You have family or personal responsibilities that require significant, consistent financial commitment** — mortgages, caregiving, tuition, medical needs

THE BOTTOM LINE

Staying employed isn't a failure of ambition — it's a strategic decision

Your paycheck funds your patience. And patience is what lets you build the business you actually *want*, not the business you're forced to rush. Quit when it makes sense — not because entrepreneurship influencers told you "real founders" have to. **Your life. Your numbers. Your decision.**

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CHAPTER SEVEN

The Systems *That Work*

When your time is limited and split across two worlds, systems are survival. Here's my entire tech stack — costs, tools, and why I chose each one. Spoiler: it costs less than most people's monthly coffee run.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- My complete $37/month tech stack
- Tools I tried and rejected
- Day-by-day weekly rhythm
- Why simple > sophisticated

My Entire *Tech Stack*

TOTAL COST · $37/MONTH

FUNCTION	TOOL	COST	WHY I USE IT
Scheduling	Calendly	**Free**	Clients book themselves — no back-and-forth
Video Calls	Google Meet	**Free**	Reliable, integrates with Gmail & Calendar
Payments	Stripe	**2.9% fee**	Simple invoicing, auto-receipts
Email	Gmail	**Free**	Works. Don't overcomplicate it.
CRM	Airtable	**Free**	Track leads, clients, revenue in one place
Design	Canva Pro	**$14.99/mo**	Content graphics, flyers, everything visual
Website	Vercel	**$20/mo**	Hosting & updates for my site
Domain	Squarespace	**~$20/yr**	idealclarity.com registration

$ THE REAL MATH

Total: approximately $37/month

You don't need fancy tools. You don't need the $297/month course platform. You don't need a designer on retainer. **You need to make offers and get clients.** Every dollar you spend on tools before you have revenue is a dollar you're using to avoid the scary part.

The Weekly Rhythm

Each day of the week has a primary theme. When you only have focused hours, ambiguity kills productivity. **Client sessions are kept flexible across all days** — I only have so many hours each week, so I protect the slots for whoever books.

DAY	PRIMARY THEME	FOCUS
Monday	**Planning**	Review week, plan content, respond to leads
Tuesday	**Delivery**	Session prep, delivery work, follow-ups
Wednesday	**Content**	Batch-schedule posts, engage with DMs
Thursday	**Sales**	Warm outreach, discovery conversations
Friday	**Deep Work**	Extended build window (through midnight)
Saturday	**Creation**	Long-form content, strategy, execution
Sunday	**Close Loops**	Client sessions, then prep for the week ahead

FLEX PRINCIPLE

The themes are defaults, not rules. **Client calls trump themes** — if someone books a strategy call on a Wednesday at 6 PM, that's what Wednesday becomes. The themes just tell me what to default to when nothing else is scheduled.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

The First *90 Days*

If I had to start over from zero today, here's exactly what I'd do — week by week, for the first 90 days. No fluff. No optional activities. The minimum viable path from "idea" to "real offers in the market."

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → Days 1-30: Foundation
- → Days 31-60: Traction
- → Days 61-90: Scale
- → 90-day success metrics

Your *Step-by-Step* Roadmap

IF I STARTED OVER TODAY

1 DAYS 01 – 30 · FOUNDATION

Build the Minimum Viable Business

- ✓ Get clear on WHO you help and WHAT you help them with
- ✓ Create *one* simple offer (don't overthink this)
- ✓ Make list of 20 warm contacts who fit your ideal client
- ✓ Set up Calendly and payment processor
- ✓ Optimize LinkedIn headline and about section
- ✓ Create one-page website (optional but helpful)

2 DAYS 31 – 60 · TRACTION

Get Your First Paying Client

- ✓ Reach out to first 10 warm contacts
- ✓ Have real conversations — make offers naturally
- ✓ Post 2-3 times per week on LinkedIn
- ✓ Land your first paying client (even if discounted)
- ✓ Deliver exceptional results — this is everything
- ✓ Ask for testimonial after week 1 of delivery

3 DAYS 61 – 90 · SCALE

Build Real Momentum

- ✓ Reach out to next 10 warm contacts (now with testimonial)
- ✓ Use testimonial in all outreach and content
- ✓ Aim for 3-5 paying clients total
- ✓ Refine your offer based on real client feedback
- ✓ Create simple systems for delivery
- ✓ Post consistently — build the long-term flywheel

> *90-day goal:* **$5,000–$10,000 in revenue, 3-5 clients, a proven model.** *That's it. Not complicated. Just consistent, focused execution.*

THE PATH FORWARD

Build While Employed. *Prove the Model.*

You don't need permission to quit. You don't need more credentials, a perfect brand, or the right moment. You need to make your first ten offers.

READY TO TAKE ACTION?

From Idea to First Offer

A 4-week intensive for corporate professionals who've been planning for 6+ months but can't seem to execute. I'll help you identify what's blocking you, remove it, and get you making 10 offers by week four — all while staying fully employed.

BOOK YOUR FREE STRATEGY CALL →

OR ENROLL IN THE PROGRAM NOW →

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

A Note *From Me*

Chi-Chi Jones

FOUNDER · IDEAL CLARITY SOLUTIONS

I've spent 15+ years in corporate, including nearly a decade at a Fortune 1 company. Along the way, I've built multiple businesses, navigated my own long season of career confusion, and come to know — intimately — what it feels like to know exactly what you want to do and still not be able to make yourself do it.

That experience is why I founded **Ideal Clarity Solutions**: to help corporate professionals at career crossroads get clarity and finally move forward. My signature methodology, **The Breakthrough Protocol™**, helps founders, consultants, and coaches identify the invisible blocks keeping them stuck — and systematically remove them.

I'm building Ideal Clarity while still working full-time in corporate — putting my own methodology into practice in real time. Not as a hobby. As a real business, with active strategy, live outreach, and ongoing conversations happening every week. Everything in this playbook comes from my actual experience: the schedule I live, the messages I'm sending, the systems I'm building, the mental game I'm playing.

This isn't theory. This isn't retrospective. This is the real thing — in motion.

LET'S CONNECT

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Stop planning. Start building.

RUNNING YOUR BUSINESS WHILE EMPLOYED FULL-TIME

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